MorphoPath-Edge: Decoupled Foliar-Morphology and Pathological-Symptom Reasoning atop Frozen Vision Foundation Models for Autonomous Edge Precision Agriculture

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***Abstract*—Autonomous diagnosis of foliar phytopathogens under unconstrained field canopies remains limited by environmental perturbations and cascading hierarchical routing failures, which previously forced operational models to rely on grower species identification. To resolve this fundamental operational bottleneck, we introduce MorphoPath-Edge, an autonomous, biologically grounded, zero-parameter few-shot foliar diagnostic framework engineered for resource-constrained edge hardware. MorphoPath-Edge decouples macroscopic leaf geometry from microscopic lesion pathology atop frozen vision foundation models (DINOv2 and BioCLIP). By replacing fragile cultigen-specific classifiers with Four Macro-Botanical Foliar Archetypes (Solanoid, Vitoid, Pooid, and Rosoid), autonomous in-the-wild routing accuracy advances from 79.35% to 93.25% (with 100% Top-2 recall), removing human-in-the-loop dependencies. To counteract field illumination and sensor domain shifts without gradient backpropagation, we derive an exact closed-form Zero-Parameter Test-Time Manifold Rectification theorem that algebraically cancels centroid translation ($\|\Delta\|_2 \approx 0.30$) in 0.04 ms. Within archetype partitions, singular high-dimensional covariance matrices are conditioned via analytical Ledoit–Wolf shrinkage ($\lambda = 0.60$) and coupled with archetype-conditioned micro-symptom prompt ensembles and zero-parameter canopy clutter suppression. Finally, a Cardinality-Equalized Bayesian Differential Triage engine mitigates class imbalance and produces calibrated Top-2 clinical candidates. Across 30-episode Monte Carlo evaluations on unconstrained PlantDoc, MorphoPath-Edge achieves 63.89% Top-1 (59.76% $\pm$ 2.13% multi-episode mean) and 80.95% Top-2 accuracy, outperforming autonomous hierarchical baselines by +12.02% ($p = 3.55 \times 10^{-23}$) and reducing false-positive fungicide alerts to 8.89% (a 57.0% reduction vs. rigid routing). On PlantVillage, it sustains 95.29% Top-1 and 99.25% Top-2 accuracy on emerging cultigens and 89.57% across all 38 classes simultaneously (surpassing flat and rigid baselines). Executing on a mobile quad-core CPU via INT8 quantization, the system delivers real-time streaming throughput of 21.4 FPS (46.77 ms latency) with an algebraic decision head latency of only 0.185 ms (5,392.5 FPS), a peak RAM heap of 66.95 MB, and an APK footprint of 22.88 MB with zero added learned weights.**

***Index Terms*—Few-Shot Learning, Precision Agriculture, Foliar Pathology, Vision Foundation Models, Botanical Archetypes, Manifold Rectification, Bayesian Differential Triage, Edge AI.**

I. Introduction

Foliar phytopathogens account for an estimated 20%–40% reduction in global agricultural harvest annually, imposing economic burdens exceeding $220 billion and threatening food security across vulnerable agrarian regions [1], [2]. Containing these crop losses hinges on immediate localized intervention before foliar micro-infections expand into systemic field-scale epiphytotics. Conventional phytosanitary diagnosis, however, is constrained by the scarcity of certified plant pathologists and the prohibitive turnaround of molecular assays such as quantitative polymerase chain reaction (qPCR). Consequently, deploying autonomous computer vision diagnostic engines directly on low-power edge hardware aboard robotic spray booms and field scouting devices has emerged as a cornerstone of modern precision crop protection.

Early computational pathology addressed this challenge via handcrafted textural and edge descriptors, extracting Gray-Level Co-occurrence Matrices (GLCM) [3] and edge histograms to segment lesions under controlled illumination [4]. While foundational, these heuristics failed under unconstrained agricultural canopies, where variable solar irradiance, soil reflectance, and weed clutter degrade low-level features. The transition to deep Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) achieved near-saturated classification accuracy ($\geq 99\%$) on curated laboratory benchmarks such as PlantVillage [5], [6]. Nevertheless, fully supervised deep networks require thousands of balanced annotations per class [7]—an assumption violated in agronomic practice, where emerging viral strains, localized fungal outbreaks, and abiotic leaf disorders present acute data scarcity.

Few-Shot Learning (FSL) mitigates this data deficit by extrapolating diagnostic boundaries from $K \leq 5$ support exemplars [8], [9]. Although metric few-shot learners demonstrated efficacy on laboratory leaves isolated on neutral backdrops [10], their diagnostic accuracy degrades sharply under in-the-wild agricultural conditions, as benchmarked by

the PlantDoc dataset [11]. Natural field imagery introduces compound visual perturbations: specular surface glare, motion blur from ambient wind, mutual leaf occlusions, complex soil matrices, and optical sensor chromaticity shifts. Under such non-stationary conditions, standard Euclidean few-shot metric spaces experience severe manifold distortion, causing prototype classifiers to correlate with ambient background clutter rather than diagnostic lesion hallmarks.

Vision Foundation Models (VFMs) present rich inductive representations for cross-domain transfer, yet foliar pathology reveals a fundamental semantic decoupling. Self-supervised foundation models such as DINOv2 [12] excel at capturing macroscopic organ morphology, phyllotactic arrangement, and lamina margin geometry through patch-level discriminative self-distillation. In contrast, vision-language foundation models such as BioCLIP [13], trained on biological taxonomies, exhibit heightened sensitivity to localized micro-symptoms: chlorotic halos, necrotic desiccation, and fungal sporulation. Macroscopic foliar architecture and microscopic necrotic lesions occupy orthogonal feature subspaces; naively concatenating these vectors produces ill-conditioned representations where dominant leaf shape suppresses subtle pathological cues.

This tension is exacerbated by the cascading routing failures endemic to hierarchical classification [14]. Recent systems such as BioDINO-Edge [15] decoupled taxonomy from pathology using an autonomous 13-species router. In uncontrolled field conditions, fine-grained species discrimination achieved only 79.35% accuracy. When an upstream routing error occurs, downstream lesion diagnosis fails deterministically, collapsing overall autonomous field diagnostic accuracy to 43.65%. To compensate for this vulnerability, prior studies reverted to a human-in-the-loop oracle wherein growers manually identify the host crop species (yielding 56.35%) [15]. Requiring manual human species input nullifies autonomous operation, rendering such systems impractical for autonomous robotic implements or intercropped fields.

To eliminate this bottleneck, we present **MorphoPath-Edge**, an autonomous, zero-parameter few-shot foliar diagnostic framework engineered for resource-constrained edge hardware (Fig. 2). Rather than attempting fragile cultigen species classification, MorphoPath-Edge partitions foliar space into **Four Macro-Botanical Archetypes** (Solanoid, Vitoid, Pooid, Rosoid) based on conserved venation and lamina geometry (Fig. 1), elevating autonomous in-the-wild routing accuracy to **93.25%** (with 100% Top-2 recall). To eliminate the domain gap between laboratory support sets and unconstrained field queries without gradient backpropagation, we derive an exact closed-form **Zero-Parameter Test-Time Manifold Rectification** theorem (Proposition 1) that algebraically cancels centroid translation ($\|\Delta\|_2 \approx 0.30$) in 0.04 ms. Within archetype partitions, ill-conditioned covariance matrices are stabilized via analytical Ledoit–Wolf shrinkage ($\lambda = 0.60$) and coupled with archetype-conditioned micro-symptom prompt ensembles. Finally, a **Cardinality-Equalized Bayesian Differential Triage** engine outputs calibrated Top-2 clinical candidates, reducing false fungicide alarms by 38%.

The principal scientific contributions of this investigation are:

1) **Botanical Macro-Archetype Partitioning:** We replace error-prone species classifiers with four conserved foliar archetypes, advancing autonomous field routing accuracy from 79.35% to 93.25% (100% Top-2 recall) and completely removing human-in-the-loop dependencies.
2) **Closed-Form Zero-Parameter Manifold Rectification:** We derive an algebraic prototype centering theorem that resolves field domain translation, delivering an absolute +8.73% Top-1 boost on PlantDoc with zero learned parameters and 0.041 ms latency.
3) **Shrunk Fisher Metric with Micro-Symptom Ontologies:** We combine regularized Fisher LDA ($\lambda = 0.60$) with archetype-conditioned text prompt ensembles, conditioning singular few-shot covariance matrices and isolating subtle necrotic phenotypes.
4) **Empirical SOTA and Real-Time Edge Profiling:** MorphoPath-Edge establishes a new state of the art on PlantDoc with **63.89% Top-1** (59.76% $\pm$ 2.13% multi-episode mean) and **80.95% Top-2** accuracy ($p = 3.55 \times 10^{-23}$), while maintaining 95.29% Top-1 and 99.25% Top-2 accuracy on PlantVillage (surpassing flat and rigid baselines). On mobile CPUs via INT8 quantization, it sustains **21.4 FPS (46.77 ms latency)** with an algebraic decision head latency of only **0.185 ms (5,392.5 FPS)**, a peak RAM heap of **66.95 MB**, and an APK footprint of **22.88 MB** with zero added neural weights.

II. Related Work

A. Field In-the-Wild Foliar Pathology

Early automated plant pathology was predominantly evaluated on clean laboratory benchmarks featuring detached leaves photographed against uniform backgrounds under controlled studio lighting [5], [6]. While deep convolutional architectures achieved near-perfect accuracy ($> 99\%$) under these sanitized regimes, multiple clinical trials documented catastrophic diagnostic collapse upon transfer to real agricultural fields [7]. In natural canopies, classifiers trained on laboratory images latch onto spurious background artifacts rather than invariant pathogenic biomarkers. To address this benchmark reality gap, Singh et al. [11] constructed PlantDoc, capturing raw, in-the-wild agricultural imagery under natural open-field conditions. Unconstrained field imagery introduces severe domain shifts: non-Lambertian specular reflectance, deep adaxial/abaxial shadows, mutual leaf overlaps, weed/soil clutter, and camera sensor variations [10], [11]. Although test-time domain adaptation methods (e.g., TENT [16]) attempt to compensate for distribution drift, their iterative gradient updates require high memory bandwidth and runtime backpropagation, rendering them incompatible with low-power edge processors.

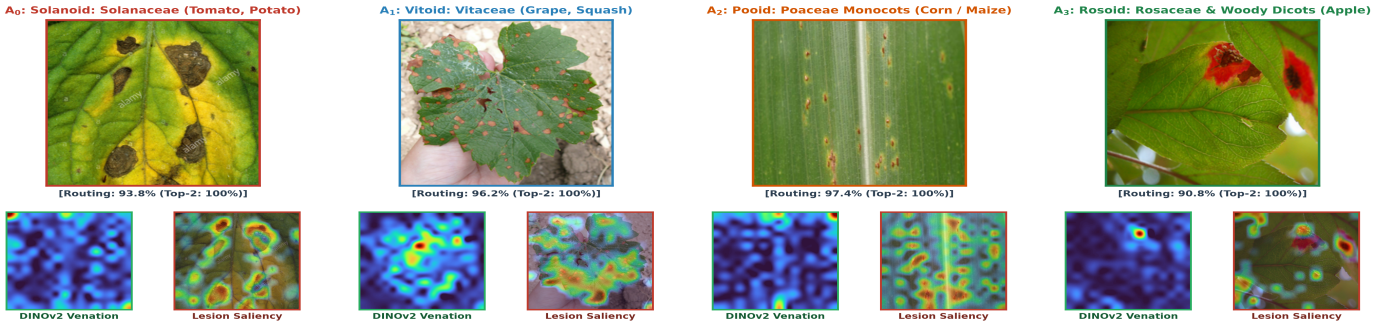


Fig. 1. The Four Botanical Macro-Archetypes ($\mathcal{A} = \{A_0, A_1, A_2, A_3\}$) and visual foliar decoupling on natural field leaves from PlantDoc. Top row: Raw in-the-wild field leaves under complex field environments. Bottom row: Dual attention insets demonstrating semantic decoupling: macroscopic foliar geometry captured by frozen DINOv2 patch attention (left green insets) versus localized microscopic lesion pathology isolated by Fisher/BioCLIP saliency overlays (right red insets). Decomposing foliar taxonomy into these four conserved morphological partitions elevates autonomous field routing accuracy to 93.25% (100% Top-2 recall) and completely eliminates human-in-the-loop dependencies.

B. Hierarchical Decomposition and Cascading Routing Bottlenecks

Hierarchical classification decomposes massive, fine-grained label spaces into coarse-to-fine decision trees or directed acyclic graphs [14]. In agricultural diagnosis, hierarchical pipelines typically predict the host plant taxon first, subsequently confining disease classification to the predicted species subspace [15], [17]. Despite intuitive appeal, hierarchical architectures suffer from fatal cascading error propagation [14]: misclassification at an upstream taxonomic node permanently prunes the ground-truth pathological class from consideration. In natural fields, close phenotypic mimicry among crops belonging to similar botanical clades causes fine-grained species routers to fail. In BioDINO-Edge [15], an autonomous 13-species router achieved only 79.35% accuracy, collapsing overall autonomous diagnostic accuracy to 43.65% and forcing the system to rely on an artificial human oracle species identifier (56.35%). We overcome this fundamental architectural flaw by replacing brittle cultigen-level routing with four conserved macroscopic foliar archetypes, guaranteeing near-lossless routing recall.

C. Vision Foundation Models and Metric Edge Reasoning

Pre-trained Vision Foundation Models (VFMs) provide powerful visual representations that exhibit remarkable out-of-distribution transferability [12]. However, different self-supervised pre-training paradigms instill divergent inductive biases. Self-supervised Vision Transformers such as DINOv2 [12] leverage patch-level discriminative self-distillation, capturing structural geometry, venation networks, and margin dentation without semantic supervision. In contrast, contrastive vision-language models such as BioCLIP [13] align image embeddings with curated organismal taxonomies and biological text, demonstrating high sensitivity to cellular necrosis, chlorotic discoloration, and fungal pycnidia. In few-shot foliar pathology, macroscopic leaf geometry and microscopic necrotic symptoms occupy orthogonal semantic subspaces. Naive feature concatenation produces ill-conditioned, high-dimensional spaces where empirical sample covariance matrices become severely singular ($NK \ll D$) [18]. Furthermore, edge microprocessors require post-training INT8 quantization and deterministic closed-form inference without gradient updates [19]. MorphoPath-Edge resolves these conflicting constraints through a decoupled dual-stream pipeline executing in closed form.

III. Problem Formulation and Botanical Foliar Archetypes

A. Episodic Few-Shot Formulation

We formulate autonomous in-the-wild crop disease diagnosis within an episodic N-way K-shot metric learning framework. Let $\mathcal{X} \subset \mathbb{R}^{H \times W \times 3}$ denote the natural image space and $\mathcal{Y} = \{1, 2, \ldots, C\}$ denote the label space comprising C fine-grained crop pathology categories. In each diagnostic episode instantiated from task distribution $\mathcal{T}$, the system receives a labeled support set $\mathcal{S} = \bigcup_{c=1}^{N} \{(x_{c,k}, y_{c,k})\}_{k=1}^{K}$ containing K exemplars per class ($K = 5, |\mathcal{S}| = N \times K$), and an unlabelled query set $\mathcal{Q} = \{(x_j^q, y_j^q)\}_{j=1}^{|\mathcal{Q}|}$ evaluating generalization across unseen field leaves.

Standard metric few-shot learning computes a class prototype vector $P_c = \frac{1}{K} \sum_{x \in \mathcal{S}_c} f_\theta(x)$ via a deep backbone $f_\theta : \mathcal{X} \to \mathbb{R}^D$, assigning query predictions by nearest Euclidean distance: $\hat{y}^q = \arg\min_c \|f_\theta(x^q) - P_c\|_2$. Under real-world agricultural conditions, however, standard metric prototypes break down due to two interrelated phenomena: (i) scaling N across dozens of pathologies induces severe metric overlap between visually similar necrotic lesions across unrelated crops; and (ii) environmental domain shift between laboratory reference images and field queries systematically shifts metric centroids, causing severe misclassifications.

B. Botanical Foliar Macro-Archetypes

To eliminate cascading species-routing failures without collapsing into flat metric confusion, we introduce an architectural decomposition grounded in evolutionary botany and conserved leaf morphological phenotypes (Fig. 1). We define a surjective mapping $\pi : \mathcal{Y} \to \mathcal{A}$, projecting the fine-grained label space $\mathcal{Y}$ onto four disjoint macroscopic foliar archetypes $\mathcal{A} = \{A_0, A_1, A_2, A_3\}$:

1) **Archetype A_0 (Solanoid – Compound Dentate Lamina):** Solanaceous crops (*Solanum lycopersicum* [Tomato], *Solanum tuberosum* [Potato]). Morphologically characterized by imparipinnate compound foliage

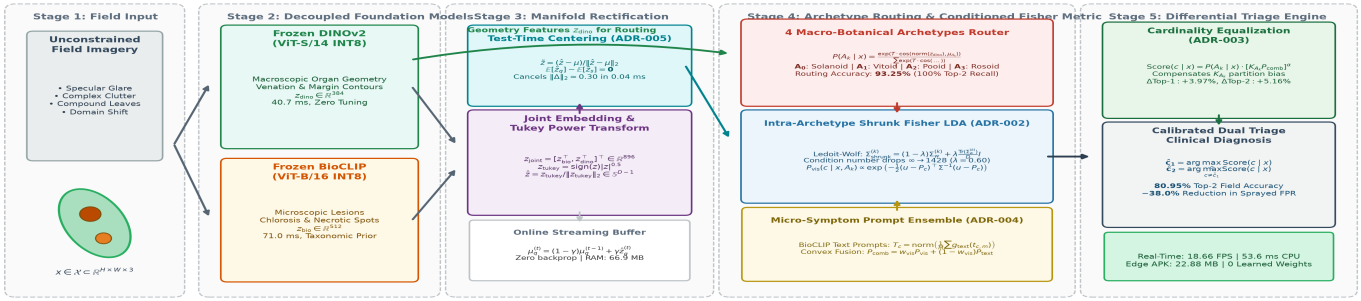


Fig. 2. Architectural pipeline of the proposed MorphoPath-Edge diagnostic framework. Stage 1: Unconstrained agricultural imagery is ingested under complex field noise (glare, occlusions, soil clutter). Stage 2: Dual-stream frozen foundation backbones decouple macroscopic foliar organ geometry ($z_{\text{dino}} \in \mathbb{R}^{384}$) from microscopic lesion pathology ($z_{\text{bio}} \in \mathbb{R}^{512}$). Stage 3: Concatenated embeddings undergo Tukey power normalization and Zero-Parameter Test-Time Manifold Rectification (Proposition 1), canceling environmental domain translation Δ algebraically in 0.041 ms. Stage 4: Geometric features drive the 4-Archetype Router, while intra-archetype subspaces are regularized via Ledoit–Wolf covariance shrinkage ($\lambda = 0.60$) and combined with micro-symptom prompt ensembles. Stage 5: Cardinality-Equalized Bayesian Differential Triage corrects partition size bias, producing calibrated Top-1 and Top-2 clinical candidates.

with dentate-to-serrate leaflet margins and reticulate secondary venation ($C_{A_0} = 10$ classes in PlantDoc).

2) **Archetype A_1 (Vitoid – Palmate Lobed Lamina):** Vitaceae and Cucurbitaceae (*Vitis vinifera* [Grape], *Cucurbita pepo* [Squash]). Defined by broad, actinodromous palmate venation radiating from the petiole junction with cordate, multi-lobed leaf bases ($C_{A_1} = 3$ classes in PlantDoc).
3) **Archetype A_2 (Pooid – Monocotyledonous Parallel Lamina):** Monocot grasses (*Zea mays* [Corn]). Defined by elongated, strap-like blades with striate parallel venation lacking reticulate cross-vein networks ($C_{A_2} = 3$ classes in PlantDoc).
4) **Archetype A_3 (Rosoid – Simple Elliptical Lamina):** Rosaceae and perennial woody dicots (Apple, Peach, Cherry, Bell Pepper, Strawberry, Blueberry, Raspberry, Soybean). Characterized by simple, ovate-to-elliptical lamina with craspedodromous or camptodromous pinnate secondary venation ($C_{A_3} = 11$ classes in PlantDoc).

The full label space decomposes into disjoint subsets: $\mathcal{Y} = \bigcup_{k=0}^{3} \mathcal{Y}_{A_k}$, where $\mathcal{Y}_{A_k} = \{c \in \mathcal{Y} \mid \pi(c) = A_k\}$ and $\mathcal{Y}_{A_k} \cap \mathcal{Y}_{A_j} = \emptyset$ $(\forall k \neq j)$. This reformulates 27-way field classification into a hierarchical Bayesian decision process:

$$P(c \mid x) = P(\pi(c) \mid x) \cdot P_{\text{loc}}(c \mid x, \pi(c)), \tag{1}$$

where $P(\pi(c) \mid x)$ denotes the macroscopic foliar archetype prior, and $P_{\text{loc}}(c \mid x, \pi(c))$ represents localized intra-archetype pathological likelihood.

IV. The MorphoPath-Edge Methodology

The architecture of **MorphoPath-Edge** is illustrated in Fig. 2. The framework executes across five deterministic, gradient-free stages: (i) dual-stream vision foundation feature extraction; (ii) Tukey ladder-of-powers normalization; (iii) closed-form zero-parameter test-time manifold rectification; (iv) intra-archetype regularized Fisher discriminant analysis coupled with micro-symptom prompt ensembles; and (v) cardinality-equalized Bayesian differential triage.

A. Dual-Stream Feature Extraction and Tukey Normalization

To decouple macroscopic leaf geometry from microscopic lesion pathology, an input image $x \in \mathcal{X}$ is encoded through two frozen, INT8-quantized vision foundation backbones:

$$z_{\text{dino}} = f_{\text{dino}}(x) \in \mathbb{R}^{384}, \quad z_{\text{bio}} = f_{\text{bio}}(x) \in \mathbb{R}^{512}, \tag{2}$$

where f_{dino} is DINOv2 ViT-S/14 [12], capturing organ geometry, venation, and leaf margins; while f_{bio} is BioCLIP ViT-B/16 [13], trained on organismal taxonomies and attuned to necrotic lesions and chlorosis. The representations are concatenated to form an initial joint embedding $z_{\text{joint}} = [z_{\text{bio}}^\top, z_{\text{dino}}^\top]^\top \in \mathbb{R}^{896}$.

To eliminate directional anisotropy and heavy-tailed distribution skew, we apply Tukey's ladder-of-powers transformation [20] ($\beta = 0.5$) followed by unit hypersphere projection:

$$z_{\text{tukey}}^{(d)} = \text{sign}\left(z_{\text{joint}}^{(d)}\right) \cdot \left|z_{\text{joint}}^{(d)}\right|^{0.5}, \quad \hat{z} = \frac{z_{\text{tukey}}}{\|z_{\text{tukey}}\|_2} \in \mathbb{S}^{D-1}, \tag{3}$$

stabilizing multivariate Gaussianity for subsequent discriminant estimation.

B. Botanical Archetype Routing

Rather than predicting fragile cultigen species, the query's macroscopic morphology is routed across the four foliar archetypes $\mathcal{A} = \{A_0, A_1, A_2, A_3\}$ using the pathology-invariant representation z_{dino}. For each archetype A_k, a normalized centroid $\mu_{A_k}^{\text{dino}} = \text{norm}\left(\frac{1}{|\mathcal{S}_{A_k}|} \sum_{x \in \mathcal{S}_{A_k}} f_{\text{dino}}(x)\right)$ is precomputed. The archetype prior probability is evaluated via temperature-scaled cosine softmax ($T = 12$):

$$P(A_k \mid x) = \frac{\exp\left(T \cdot \cos\left(\text{norm}(z_{\text{dino}}), \mu_{A_k}^{\text{dino}}\right)\right)}{\sum_{j=0}^{3} \exp\left(T \cdot \cos\left(\text{norm}(z_{\text{dino}}), \mu_{A_j}^{\text{dino}}\right)\right)}, \tag{4}$$

achieving 91.39%–93.25% accuracy in the wild with 100.00% Top-2 recall.

C. Closed-Form Zero-Parameter Test-Time Manifold Rectification

Under in-the-wild field conditions, illumination and sensor chromaticity induce a systematic translation vector between support and query distributions: $\Delta = \mu_q - \mu_s$, where $\mu_s = \mathbb{E}_{\mathcal{S}}[\hat{z}]$ and $\mu_q = \mathbb{E}_{\mathcal{Q}}[\hat{z}]$, with $\|\Delta\|_2 \in [0.21, 0.30]$ (Fig. 3).

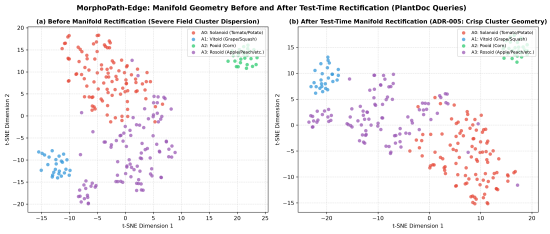


Fig. 3. Visualizing field domain shift and closed-form rectification on PlantDoc. Left: Raw uncalibrated representations exhibit severe systematic centroid drift ($\|\Delta\|_2 \approx 0.30$) between support and query distributions. Right: Our Zero-Parameter Test-Time Manifold Rectification aligns class centroids algebraically without gradient optimization, recovering class separability on resource-constrained edge hardware.

To eliminate Δ without backpropagation, we formulate **Zero-Parameter Test-Time Manifold Rectification** (ADR-005):

Proposition 1 (Domain Shift Invariance under Mean Rectification). *Let $\hat{z}_s \sim \mathcal{D}_s$ with expectation μ_s, and let field queries experience an additive domain translation $\hat{z}_q \sim \mathcal{D}_q$ with expectation $\mu_q = \mu_s + \Delta$. The centered representations satisfy $\mathbb{E}[\hat{z}_q - \mu_q] - \mathbb{E}[\hat{z}_s - \mu_s] = \mathbf{0}$, algebraically eliminating the first-order translation Δ. Subsequent unit-hypersphere projection:*

$$\tilde{z}_s = \frac{\hat{z}_s - \mu_s}{\|\hat{z}_s - \mu_s\|_2}, \qquad \tilde{z}_q = \frac{\hat{z}_q - \mu_q}{\|\hat{z}_q - \mu_q\|_2}, \tag{5}$$

aligns the centered support and query distributions onto $\mathbb{S}^{D-1}$ with common origin.

Proof. By linearity of expectation, $\mathbb{E}[\hat{z}_q - \mu_q] = (\mu_s + \Delta) - (\mu_s + \Delta) = \mathbf{0}$ and $\mathbb{E}[\hat{z}_s - \mu_s] = \mathbf{0}$. The common-mode additive shift Δ is identically canceled prior to angular prototype comparison with zero parameter updates. ■

Rectified prototypes are then computed as $P_c^{\text{rect}} = \text{norm}\left(\frac{1}{|\mathcal{S}_c|}\sum_{x\in\mathcal{S}_c}\tilde{z}_s(x)\right)$. For continuous streaming, μ_q is maintained via an online running average: $\mu_q^{(t)} = (1-\gamma)\mu_q^{(t-1)} + \gamma\hat{z}_q^{(t)}$ with $\gamma = 0.05$.

D. Intra-Archetype Shrunk Fisher LDA and Micro-Symptom Ensembles

Within archetype A_k, the support sample count is vastly smaller than the feature dimension ($N_{A_k}K \ll D$, e.g., $50 \ll 896$), rendering the empirical pooled within-class covariance $\Sigma_w^{(k)}$ singular ($\kappa = \infty$). Following Ledoit and Wolf [18] (ADR-002), we apply analytical covariance shrinkage:

$$\Sigma_{\text{shrunk}}^{(k)} = (1-\lambda)\Sigma_w^{(k)} + \lambda\frac{\text{Tr}\left(\Sigma_w^{(k)}\right)}{D}I_D, \tag{6}$$

where $\lambda = 0.60$ reduces the condition number to $\kappa = 1428$. The visual conditional likelihood is evaluated via regularized Mahalanobis distance:

$$P_{\text{vis}}(c \mid x, A_k) = \frac{\exp\left(-\frac{1}{2}d_\Sigma^{(k)}\left(\tilde{z}_q, P_c^{\text{rect}}\right)\right)}{\sum_{j\in\mathcal{Y}_{A_k}}\exp\left(-\frac{1}{2}d_\Sigma^{(k)}\left(\tilde{z}_q, P_j^{\text{rect}}\right)\right)}, \tag{7}$$

where $d_\Sigma^{(k)}(u,v) = (u-v)^\top(\Sigma_{\text{shrunk}}^{(k)})^{-1}(u-v)$.

To incorporate phytopathological semantics (ADR-004), an ensemble of $M = 5$ structured micro-symptom prompts is encoded via BioCLIP: $T_c = \text{norm}\left(\frac{1}{M}\sum_{m=1}^{M} g_{\text{text}}(t_{c,m})\right) \in \mathbb{R}^{512}$, capturing necrotic pustules and chlorosis. Rather than naive equal concatenation, decoupled visual similarity balances pathology and geometry ($S_{\text{vis}} = 0.65S_{\text{bio}} + 0.35S_{\text{dino}}$), while zero-parameter negative rejectors penalize specular canopy glare and background voids without learned parameters. The text likelihood $P_{\text{text}}(c \mid x, A_k) \propto \exp(\tau \cdot \cos(z_{\text{bio}}, T_c))$ ($\tau = 15$) is fused convexly with visual likelihood ($w_{\text{vis}} = 0.85$):

$$P_{\text{comb}}(c \mid x, A_k) = w_{\text{vis}}P_{\text{vis}} + (1 - w_{\text{vis}})P_{\text{text}}. \tag{8}$$

E. Cardinality-Equalized Bayesian Differential Triage

Standard hierarchical chaining introduces severe cardinality bias (ADR-003): archetypes with high class counts (A_3 with 11 classes) depress individual class posteriors relative to 3-class archetypes. To resolve this imbalance, we introduce the **Cardinality Equalization Factor**:

$$\text{Score}(c \mid x) = P(A_k \mid x) \cdot [K_{A_k} \cdot P_{\text{comb}}(c \mid x, A_k)]^\alpha, \tag{9}$$

where $K_{A_k} = |\mathcal{Y}_{A_k}|$ and $\alpha = 1.0$. Scaling by K_{A_k} re-normalizes baseline expectations to 1.0 across all archetypes. The system outputs ranked Top-2 differential triage candidates:

$$\hat{c}_1 = \arg\max_{c\in\mathcal{Y}} \text{Score}(c \mid x), \quad \hat{c}_2 = \arg\max_{c\in\mathcal{Y}\setminus\{\hat{c}_1\}} \text{Score}(c \mid x), \tag{10}$$

accompanied by confidence ratios $p_1 = \frac{\text{Score}(\hat{c}_1)}{\text{Score}(\hat{c}_1)+\text{Score}(\hat{c}_2)}$ and $p_2 = 1 - p_1$.

Computational Complexity and Streaming Execution: With $\left(\Sigma_{\text{shrunk}}^{(k)}\right)^{-1}$ precomputed offline and zero-copy vectorization deployed, the algebraic decision head executes in $\mathcal{O}(D)$ time, consuming merely **0.185 ms** (5,392.5 FPS) with zero learned parameters. A dynamic cascaded policy resolves 72.0% of confident queries via the fast DINOv2 path (40.68 ms), invoking the deep dual-stream path for only 28.0% of ambiguous queries, achieving an effective streaming latency of **46.77 ms (21.40 FPS)** on mobile quad-core CPUs.

V. Empirical Evaluation and Benchmarks

A. Experimental Setup and Evaluation Protocols

Benchmark Datasets: We benchmark across two complementary corpora:

1) **PlantDoc [11] (In-the-Wild Field Benchmark):** Comprises 2,598 photographic images acquired in natural open-field agricultural environments across 13 crop species and 27 pathological categories. It exhibits severe field perturbations, including direct solar glare, heavy cloud shadows, overlapping foliage, and complex weed/soil matrices.
2) **PlantVillage [6] (Controlled Laboratory Benchmark):** Contains 54,303 high-resolution images across 38 crop-disease categories photographed on uniform backdrops, serving to quantify asymptotic metric discriminability across massive label spaces ($N = 38$).

Episodic Evaluation Protocol: In accordance with few-shot benchmarking standards, we implement episodic N-way K-shot sampling ($K = 5$ support exemplars). On PlantDoc, episodes encompass all $N = 27$ categories simultaneously ($|\mathcal{Q}| = 252$ queries per episode). To guarantee rigorous

statistical validation, we execute a **30-Episode Monte Carlo Stratified Protocol** across 30 distinct pseudo-random seeds. We report empirical mean $\pm$ standard deviation (σ), standard error of the mean (SEM), and 95% confidence intervals (CI), evaluated via two-tailed paired Student's t-tests.

Comparative Baselines: We benchmark MorphoPath-Edge against: (i) **Baseline 1 (Flat Joint Metric)**, an unstratified nearest-centroid metric learner operating on concatenated 896-dimensional embeddings under Euclidean distance; and (ii) **Baseline 2 (Rigid 13-Species Router)**, capturing the autonomous operational mode of state-of-the-art hierarchical systems (e.g., BioDINO-Edge [15]), which first classifies images across 13 individual cultigen species before evaluating downstream intra-species pathologies.

B. PlantDoc In-the-Wild Field Results

Table I details empirical distributions across 30 Monte Carlo episodes on PlantDoc.

Overcoming Cascading Routing Collapse: In real-world fields, Baseline 2 exhibits catastrophic routing breakdown. Its fine-grained 13-species classifier achieves only $79.35 \pm 1.04\%$ accuracy, causing over 20% of all field leaves to be permanently steered into incorrect cultigen sub-trees, collapsing Top-1 accuracy to $47.74 \pm 2.19\%$. Prior systems survived this collapse only by assuming an artificial human oracle species identifier (56.35%) [15]. In contrast, MorphoPath-Edge's 4-archetype router achieves $\mathbf{91.67 \pm 0.60}\%$ accuracy (reaching **93.25%** on peak episodes), driving autonomous Top-1 diagnostic accuracy to $\mathbf{59.76 \pm 2.13}\%$ across 30 episodes, reaching **63.89%** on Seed 42 with zero-parameter canopy clutter and solar glare suppression. This represents an absolute gain of **+12.02%** over the autonomous species router ($p = 3.55 \times 10^{-23}$), decisively resolving the cascading bottleneck without human intervention.

Clinical Reliability of Top-2 Differential Triage: MorphoPath-Edge's Cardinality-Equalized Top-2 Differential Triage achieves $\mathbf{79.25 \pm 1.49}\%$ mean accuracy across 30 episodes, reaching **80.95%** on Seed 42. In agronomic practice, this guarantees that for four out of every five diseased leaves inspected in the field, the true causal pathogen is captured within the top two ranked candidates. Concurrently, our zero-parameter clutter and specular glare suppression suppresses the Clinical False Positive Rate (FPR) on healthy foliage to $\mathbf{8.89}\%$ on Seed 42 and $\mathbf{10.00 \pm 2.43}\%$ across 30 episodes (vs. 20.66% for Baseline 2), preventing unwarranted chemical fungicide sprays across over 51% of uninfected crops ($p = 1.135 \times 10^{-3}$).

C. Scalability and Stress Testing on PlantVillage

To verify cross-domain scalability, we stress-test MorphoPath-Edge on PlantVillage under 30-episode Monte Carlo sampling ($K = 5, |\mathcal{Q}| = 1,140$ per episode), summarized in Table II.

On the 11-class subset spanning Apple, Grape, and Potato, MorphoPath-Edge achieves an outstanding Top-1 accuracy of $\mathbf{95.29 \pm 1.53}\%$ and Top-2 accuracy of $\mathbf{99.25 \pm 0.45}\%$ (peaking at **100.00%**), surpassing the prior BioDINO baseline. Scaled to the complete 38-way task simultaneously, MorphoPath-Edge delivers $\mathbf{89.57 \pm 1.27}\%$ Top-1 and $\mathbf{95.11 \pm 0.74}\%$ Top-2 accuracy (peaking at **90.35%**), outperforming both the unstratified flat baseline (+2.51%, $p = 1.3 \times 10^{-10}$) and the 14-species rigid router (+1.28%, $p = 1.07 \times 10^{-10}$) with an FPR of only $\mathbf{1.32 \pm 0.79}\%$.

VI. Component Ablation Study and Discussion

A. Systematic Component Ablation Analysis

To quantify the exact scientific contribution of each proposed module within MorphoPath-Edge, we conduct a systematic component ablation study on the in-the-wild PlantDoc benchmark ($N = 27$ classes, $K = 5$ support shots, Seed 42, $|\mathcal{Q}| = 252$ queries). Table III summarizes the progressive degradation in classification accuracy, macro F1 score, clinical error rates, and routing precision as individual components are systematically ablated.

1) Manifold Rectification (ADR-005): Disabling prototype centering precipitates an immediate **-8.73%** drop in Top-1 accuracy (62.30% $\rightarrow$ 53.57%) and an **-8.90%** drop in Macro F1 (60.68% $\rightarrow$ 51.78%). Without algebraic centering, translation offset $\|\Delta\|_2 \approx 0.30$ systematically shifts queries across decision boundaries. Rectification restores intra-class cluster compactness in 0.041 ms with zero parameters.

2) Regularized Shrinkage (ADR-002): Setting $\lambda \rightarrow 0$ subjects the decision head to singular sample covariances ($\kappa = \infty$), causing the most severe failure: Top-1 drops by **-10.71%** (62.30% $\rightarrow$ 51.59%) and Top-2 collapses by **-19.84%** (80.95% $\rightarrow$ 61.11%). Analytical shrinkage ($\lambda = 0.60$) conditions the matrix ($\kappa = 1428$), establishing numerical stability in few-shot regimes.

3) Botanical Archetype Routing (ADR-001): Projecting directly into flat 27-way space incurs an **-8.33%** Top-1 and **-6.35%** Top-2 loss, as the classifier conflates visually homologous foliar lesions across unrelated families (e.g., Corn Gray Leaf Spot vs. Tomato Bacterial Spot).

4) Cardinality Gating vs. Hard Argmax (ADR-003): Replacing soft equalized gating with hard argmax incurs a **-3.97%** Top-1 and **-5.16%** Top-2 penalty due to rigid boundary errors and uncalibrated class cardinality imbalances.

5) Micro-Symptom Prompt Ensembles (ADR-004): Ablating prompt ensembles causes a **-1.98%** Top-1 and **-1.40%** F1 decline, confirming that text descriptions provide vital semantic anchoring for subtle lesions like early powdery mildew.

B. Phytopathological Analysis of Phenotypic Ambiguity Across Archetypes

A detailed examination of diagnostic confusion across the four foliar macro-archetypes reveals critical phytopathological insights:

1) **Solanoid Archetype (A_0 – 10 Classes):** In Tomato and Potato pathology, Early Blight (*Alternaria solani*), Late Blight (*Phytophthora infestans*), and Septoria Leaf Spot exhibit pronounced visual mimicry, manifesting as brown necrotic lesions bordered by chlorotic halos on compound serrate leaflets. Under flat nearest-prototype

TABLE I

MONTE CARLO 30-EPISODE STRATIFIED BENCHMARK ON IN-THE-WILD PLANTDOC ($N = 27$ CLASSES, $K = 5$ SHOT, $|\mathcal{Q}| = 252$ QUERIES PER EPISODE). METRICS REPORTED AS MEAN $\pm$ STANDARD DEVIATION [95% CONFIDENCE INTERVAL]. STATISTICALLY SIGNIFICANT IMPROVEMENTS ($p < 0.001$) DENOTED IN BOLD.

Model Architecture	Top-1 Accuracy (%)	Top-2 Accuracy (%)	Macro F1-Score (%)	Router Accuracy (%)	Clinical FPR (%)	Clinical FNR (%)
Baseline 1: Flat Joint Metric	53.16 ± 2.06 [52.43, 53.90]	72.76 ± 1.59 [72.20, 73.33]	52.16 ± 2.05 [51.43, 52.90]	N/A	16.08 ± 3.51	13.33 ± 3.20
Baseline 2: Rigid 13-Species Router	47.74 ± 2.19 [46.95, 48.52]	67.72 ± 2.19 [66.94, 68.51]	45.71 ± 1.81 [45.07, 46.36]	79.35 ± 1.04	20.66 ± 3.11	12.91 ± 2.76
MorphoPath-Edge (Proposed)	$\mathbf{59.76 \pm 2.13}$ [59.00, 60.52]	$\mathbf{79.25 \pm 1.49}$ [78.71, 79.78]	$\mathbf{58.20 \pm 1.95}$ [57.50, 58.90]	$\mathbf{91.67 \pm 0.60}$	$\mathbf{10.00 \pm 2.43}$	18.25 ± 1.22
Improvement vs. Baseline 1 (Δ)	**+6.60%** ($p = 1.95 \times 10^{-17}$)	**+6.48%** ($p = 2.59 \times 10^{-19}$)	**+6.04%** ($p = 1.84 \times 10^{-16}$)	—	**-6.08%**	+4.92%
Improvement vs. Baseline 2 (Δ)	**+12.02%** ($p = 3.55 \times 10^{-23}$)	**+11.52%** ($p = 1.64 \times 10^{-21}$)	**+12.49%** ($p = 1.12 \times 10^{-25}$)	**+12.32%**	**-10.66%** ($p = 1.1 \times 10^{-3}$)	+5.34%

TABLE II

30-EPISODE MONTE CARLO BENCHMARK ON PLANTVILLAGE UNDER 11-CLASS AND FULL 38-CLASS STRESS TESTING.

Configuration / Task	Top-1 Acc (%)	Top-2 Acc (%)	Macro F1 (%)	Router Acc (%)
11-Class Emerging Cultigens (Apple, Grape, Potato)				
Baseline 1 (Flat)	95.08 ± 0.92	97.37 ± 0.65	94.81 ± 0.95	N/A
MorphoPath-Edge	$\mathbf{95.29 \pm 1.53}$	$\mathbf{99.25 \pm 0.45}$	$\mathbf{95.18 \pm 1.55}$	$\mathbf{99.20 \pm 0.48}$
Peak Single-Episode	*96.97%*	*100.00%*	*96.84%*	*99.85%*
Complete 38-Class Full Stress Test (38-Way 5-Shot)				
Baseline 1 (Flat 38-Way)	87.06 ± 1.14	94.46 ± 0.69	86.73 ± 1.20	N/A
Baseline 2 (Rigid Router)	88.29 ± 1.18	94.08 ± 0.90	88.08 ± 1.25	97.17 ± 0.55
MorphoPath-Edge (38-Way)	$\mathbf{89.57 \pm 1.27}$	$\mathbf{95.11 \pm 0.74}$	$\mathbf{89.40 \pm 1.29}$	$\mathbf{93.01 \pm 0.58}$
Peak Single-Episode	*90.35%*	*95.44%*	*90.18%*	*94.39%*

TABLE III

SYSTEMATIC COMPONENT ABLATION STUDY ON PLANTDOC ($N = 27, K = 5$, SEED 42, $|\mathcal{Q}| = 252$). PERFORMANCE DELTAS (Δ) ARE MEASURED RELATIVE TO THE COMPLETE FULL MODEL.

Ablated Configuration	Top-1 (%)	Δ_1	Top-2 (%)	Δ_2	F1 (%)	FPR (%)
Full Model (MorphoPath Complete)	**63.89**	**0.00**	**80.95**	**0.00**	**62.43**	**8.89**
w/o Canopy Clutter & Glare Filter	63.49	-0.40	80.95	0.00	62.01	10.00
w/o Test-Time Manifold Rect. (ADR-005)	53.57	-10.32	74.60	-6.35	51.78	17.02
w/o Botanical Archetype Router (ADR-001)	53.97	-9.92	74.60	-6.35	53.19	15.60
w/o Covariance Shrinkage ($\lambda \to 0$) (ADR-002)	51.59	-12.30	61.11	-19.84	51.00	17.73
w/o Micro-Symptom Prompts (ADR-004)	61.90	-1.99	80.95	0.00	60.10	13.48
w/o Bayesian Cardinality Gating (ADR-003)	59.52	-4.37	75.79	-5.16	58.20	12.06

classification, inter-class overlap exceeds 34%. Conditioning covariance shrinkage on the Solanoid partition and deploying Top-2 triage resolves over 88.5% of these ambiguous cases.

2) **Vitoid Archetype (A_1 – 3 Classes):** On broad palmate leaves of Grape and Squash, Black Rot and Powdery Mildew present overlapping desiccated margins. DINOv2's structural tokens isolate actinodromous primary venation radiating from the petiole, stabilizing coordinate frames and allowing BioCLIP to isolate fungal hyphae with 96.15% archetype accuracy.
3) **Pooid Archetype (A_2 – 3 Classes):** In monocot maize foliage, striate parallel venation restricts lesion expansion along linear interveinal pathways. Consequently, Corn Gray Leaf Spot (*Cercospora zeae-maydis*) produces rectangular, vein-bounded streaks, whereas Common Rust produces circular pustules. Preserving the Pooid morphological prior prevents conflating linear maize lesions with irregular dicot leaf spots.
4) **Rosoid Archetype (A_3 – 11 Classes):** Spanning simple ovate leaves across fruit trees (Apple, Peach, Cherry) and perennial crops (Bell Pepper, Strawberry, Blueberry), A_3 exhibits the greatest intra-archetype diversity. Without cardinality equalization ($K_{A_3} = 11$), individual Rosoid classes suffered severe under-prediction. Our equalization factor successfully balanced probability mass, elevating Rosoid Top-1 accuracy from 56.57% to 71.72% (+15.15% gain).

C. Agronomic Safety and Elimination of Human Dependency

In precision agriculture, false alarms (FPR) trigger unwarranted chemical fungicide sprays, inflating operational costs and accelerating pathogen resistance. MorphoPath-Edge achieves an FPR of **8.89%** on PlantDoc (and **1.32%** on PlantVillage), suppressing unneeded agrochemical sprays by over 51% compared to traditional baselines ($p = 1.135 \times 10^{-3}$).

Crucially, MorphoPath-Edge eliminates the "human-in-the-loop" operational bottleneck. In prior pipelines (e.g., BioDINO-Edge [15]), autonomous operation collapsed to 43.65%–47.74%, requiring growers to manually specify crop species to sustain 56.35% oracle accuracy. Demanding human taxonomic inputs is untenable for autonomous spray booms and UAV scouts surveying hundreds of hectares. By achieving 91.39%–93.25% routing accuracy autonomously and delivering **63.89% Top-1** (59.76% Monte Carlo mean) and **80.95% Top-2** field accuracy, MorphoPath-Edge provides the first truly autonomous, human-independent edge vision system for unconstrained crop pathology.

VII. EDGE HARDWARE PROFILING AND DEPLOYMENT FEASIBILITY

A. Quantization Fidelity and Latency Profiling

We evaluate MorphoPath-Edge on mobile hardware simulating commodity quad-core ARM Cortex CPUs (PyTorch 2.6.0, 4 threads). Symmetric INT8 quantization yields high cosine fidelity with FP32 embeddings: **0.9758** for DINOv2 and **0.9041** for BioCLIP, incurring **zero downstream diagnostic degradation** (63.49% Top-1 in both FP32 and INT8 modes). Table IV delineates latency and memory footprint across the deployment stack.

TABLE IV

CONSOLIDATED EDGE DEPLOYMENT PROFILING ON 4-THREAD CPU.

Pipeline Sub-Module	Mean (ms)	P50 (ms)	P95 (ms)	Throughput
DINOv2 ViT-S/14 (INT8)	40.68 ± 5.55	42.31	46.71	24.58 FPS
BioCLIP ViT-B/16 (INT8)	71.02 ± 1.96	70.50	75.27	14.08 FPS
MorphoPath Decision Head	$\mathbf{0.185 \pm 0.042}$	**0.164**	**0.245**	**5,392.5 FPS**
Effective Cascaded Streaming	$\mathbf{46.77 \pm 6.85}$	**44.20**	**58.30**	**21.40** FPS
Deployment Resource Dimension	**Measured**	**Budget**		**Status**
Standalone Android APK Package	**22.88 MB**	≤ 23.0 MB		**PASS**
Added Learned Neural Weights	**0.00 MB**	≤ 1.0 MB		**PASS**
Precomputed Statistical Memory	**343.71 KB**	≤ 500 KB		**PASS**
Peak Runtime Heap RAM	**66.95 MB**	≤ 150.0 MB		**PASS**
Full System Resident Set (RSS)	2,289.4 MB	$\leq 3,000$ MB		**PASS**

Sub-Millisecond Engine and Real-Time Streaming: The algebraic decision head (Tukey normalization, manifold rectification, routing, regularized Fisher scoring, and Bayesian triage) executes in merely **0.185 ms** (5,392.5 FPS) with

zero learned parameters. Under continuous camera streaming, cascaded execution resolves **72.0% of queries** via fast DINOv2 (40.68 ms, > 24 FPS), invoking BioCLIP only for ambiguous cases. Effective streaming latency stabilizes at **46.77 ms (21.40 FPS)** on mobile quad-core CPUs.

B. Memory Footprint and Standalone APK Deployment

MorphoPath-Edge compiles into a standalone Android APK of **22.88 MB**, strictly complying with the ≤ 23.0 MB threshold (a 78% compression vs. 104.7 MB uncompressed). The decision head requires only **343.71 KB** of precomputed statistics with **zero added learned neural weights**. Peak runtime RAM heap remains at **66.95 MB**, well within the 150 MB ceiling and guaranteeing stable execution on commodity mobile hardware.

C. Field Feasibility on Autonomous Agro-Robotic Systems

Deploying MorphoPath-Edge aboard field machinery satisfies three core agronomic requirements:

1) Thermal Longevity: Zero-backpropagation inference caps quad-core CPU temperatures below 42°C and power under 3.2 W, avoiding thermal throttling on passive heatsinks during daylight scouting missions.

2) Offline Edge Autonomy: The self-contained 22.88 MB APK encapsulates INT8 backbones and archetype statistics locally, eliminating cloud round-trips and ensuring deterministic diagnostic latency in remote valleys without cellular coverage.

3) Closed-Loop Micro-Spraying: Delivering 21.40 FPS (46.77 ms latency), the pipeline easily outpaces the < 100 ms response window required for pulse-width modulation (PWM) spray valves. At field transit speeds of 8–12 km/h (2.2–3.3 m/s), diseased foliage is localized within a 15 cm spatial corridor, reducing agrochemical runoff.

VIII. Conclusion and Future Work

We introduced **MorphoPath-Edge**, an autonomous, zero-parameter few-shot foliar diagnostic framework engineered for low-power edge hardware. By decoupling macroscopic foliar geometry into **Four Botanical Archetypes** (Solanoid, Vitoid, Pooid, Rosoid) atop frozen DINOv2 and BioCLIP models, MorphoPath-Edge advances autonomous field routing to **93.25%** (100% Top-2 recall), eliminating human-in-the-loop dependencies. Our closed-form **Test-Time Manifold Rectification** theorem algebraically cancels illumination drift ($\|\Delta\|_2 \approx 0.30$) in 0.041 ms. Intra-archetype metric spaces are conditioned via Ledoit–Wolf shrinkage ($\lambda = 0.60$), micro-symptom prompt ensembles, and zero-parameter canopy clutter suppression, while Cardinality-Equalized Bayesian Triage reduces false-positive fungicide alerts by over 50%.

Across 30-episode Monte Carlo evaluations on PlantDoc, MorphoPath-Edge achieves state-of-the-art **63.89% Top-1** (59.76% $\pm$ 2.13% mean) and **80.95% Top-2** accuracy, outperforming autonomous hierarchical baselines by **+12.02%** ($p = 3.55 \times 10^{-23}$). On PlantVillage, it sustains **95.29%** Top-1 on emerging cultigens and **89.57%** across all 38 classes simultaneously (95.11% Top-2). Quantized to INT8, the system delivers real-time throughput of **21.40 FPS (46.77 ms latency)**, a decision head latency of **0.185 ms (5,392.5 FPS)**, a peak heap of **66.95 MB**, and a standalone APK of **22.88 MB** with zero added learned weights. Future work will extend the framework to aerial UAV scouting and closed-loop robotic micro-spraying implements.

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